

FREE PLAYBOOK · FIELD KIT · TAP THE REST OF YOU

Bricolage

Lead with what you have — memory, tools, and people already in the room.

Solve unprecedented problems with what's already here, not the perfect plan you don't have yet. Five practices. One 60-second forage. One overlooked-resource deck.

Jeffrey Sanchez-Burks

Human Mode (HarperCollins, 2027) · Part II

William Russell Kelly Professor · Michigan Ross

jsb-humanmode.vercel.app/bricolage

The meeting that waited for perfect resources

You have been in the room. The problem is real. The timeline is short. Someone says, not unkindly, that you cannot move until headcount lands, until the vendor is chosen, until the data is complete, until the budget cycle turns.

So the room waits. Not because there is nothing to work with. Because the room has been trained to treat missing ideal conditions as a stop sign. The people at the table have already solved stranger problems in other lives, and none of that is invited into the conversation.

Bricolage is adaptive resourcefulness: creating solutions from whatever is at hand rather than waiting for ideal conditions. You become a Bricoleur by foraging your full human portfolio under pressure, and turning what you find into a rough, usable next move.

Everyone tells you to think outside the box. Work mode locked the boxes worth opening: a summer job you hated at sixteen, your grandmother’s garden, a film you’d swear you forgot.

What a Bricoleur is (and isn’t)

A Bricoleur is...	A Bricoleur is not...
A skillful forager of lived experience	A scrounger who never asks for real resources when needed
Someone who recombines tools and people at hand	Someone who glorifies underfunding as virtue
Comfortable shipping a rough artifact	Someone who performs scrappiness for show
Curious about <i>who solved something like this?</i>	Someone who only trusts best practice from elsewhere

The engineer waits for the right materials and the clean plan. The Bricoleur starts with the materials already on the table, including the human ones, and builds something that can be tested today. Most hard problems need both.

The three materials

Before you escalate the gap list, inventory these three.

1. **Lived memory** — people, roles, failures that taught you a shape; grandmother, former boss, child.
2. **Tools at hand** — licensed software, half-built process, Slack threads, junior with data, abandoned template.
3. **Constraints as design** — time, money, politics, “we can’t do that here” force combination.

EXERCISE A

Overlooked resource deck

When the official toolkit has already been listed and still fails.

1. Name the stuck problem in one sentence.
2. Draw one card (person, tool, constraint, or locked box).
3. Ask: How does this open a next move on my problem?
4. Write one usable step for this week.

Do this week: One draw before you escalate the gap list.

PRACTICE 1 · BRICOLAGE LAB TWIN

60-Second Memory Forage

When you are stuck, or the room is waiting for conditions that will not arrive this week.

1. Name the challenge in one sentence.
2. Set a 60-second timer.
3. Summon a specific person (grandmother, former boss, child...).
4. Ask: How would they solve this with what they had?
5. Write one usable next move, not the perfect plan.

Why: Most of what you need is not missing. It is uninvited.

Anti-pattern: Nostalgia. Output is a next move, not a story.

PRACTICE 2

Inventory the room before the gap list

When the first slide is “what we need.”

1. People already in the room (or one Slack hop away).
2. Tools already paid for.
3. Prior attempts that left reusable scraps.
4. Then list the true gaps.

Before we name what we don't have, let's name what we do, including who in this room has solved a cousin of this problem somewhere else.

Anti-pattern: Performative optimism. Be specific: names, tools, artifacts.

PRACTICE 3

Two odd tools, one problem

When the team is stuck in a single-domain frame.

1. Pick the stuck problem.
2. Name two tools or disciplines that “don't belong” together.
3. Ask what a solution looks like if both must show up.
4. End with: what will we try in 48 hours?

Examples: Support transcripts + roadmap · Finance model + frontline story · Design critique + sales objections.

PRACTICE 4

Rough artifact in 24 hours

When the group is polishing a deck before testing anything.

1. Define the smallest thing that would teach you something true.
2. One-page prototype, five calls, one ugly scenario, one-week pilot.
3. Ship before the next “we need more research” loop.

We don't need the finished version. We need a rough artifact by tomorrow that can be wrong in public.

Anti-pattern: Rough as low standards. Rough means early and testable.

PRACTICE 5

Debrief: what did you almost ignore?

After a win, a miss, or a scramble.

1. What did we use that was already here?
2. What memory or person changed the approach?
3. What did we almost dismiss as “not professional enough”?
4. What will we inventory first next time?

Anti-pattern: Only celebrating heroics. Celebrate foraging, not overwork.

Anti-patterns

Anti-pattern	Sounds like	Better move
Ideal-conditions waiting	“We’ll start when we have X.”	Forage + rough artifact this week
Performative scrappiness	“We ship chaos and call it culture.”	Constraints as design, not identity theater
Specialist silo	“That’s not how we do it in our function.”	Two odd tools, one problem
Refusing real asks	“Bricolage means never resource the team.”	Forage first; then make the specific ask

Bricolage is not a license to under-invest forever. It is a method for starting when the map is incomplete, and for learning what is truly missing.

Your 30-day loop

Week	Focus
1	Run the 60-Second Memory Forage three times on live stuck points
2	Open one meeting with room inventory before the gap list
3	Force one “two odd tools” recombination + 48-hour try
4	Ship one rough artifact; debrief what you almost ignored

Go deeper (Field Kit)

- **Read the Room** — Emotional Aperture Measure
- **Drop the Certainty Theater** — Pulse Check + Competent Humility playbook
- **Skip the Pep Talk** — Quiet Understanding field guide
- *Human Mode* (HarperCollins, 2027) — Part II at full length
- Live exercises · jsb-humanmode.vercel.app/bricolage

You do not need ideal conditions to begin.

You need a forage, a recombination, and a rough artifact.

The leader who waits for perfect resources will be late to the only moment that mattered. The leader who forages becomes a Bricoleur.

Human Mode, Always.

Jeffrey Sanchez-Burks

Author of *Human Mode* (2027, HarperCollins)

William Russell Kelly Professor · Michigan Ross

Free playbook · The Human Mode, Always™ Field Kit · jsb-humanmode.vercel.app/bricolage